

the warriors, who ensured that the towns subjugated by the Aztecs remained submissive—little mercy being shown to those who revolted.

While the Aztecs provided some security to their subjects, they gave little else. At Tenochtitlan, artificial islands (*chinampas*) were created at great expense to expand the land available to produce food, but no such works were carried out for the subject cities. Defeated states did not provide troops for the Aztec army, and so did not share in the spoils of future victory, and little effort was made to propagate the Aztec language. It was an empire built on fear and in the end it proved brittle: when it was invaded by a small party of Spaniards led by Cortés in 1519, the subject peoples rallied to the newcomers rather than defending the Aztecs, and the empire collapsed within two years.

Inca beginnings

The Incas, whose heartland lay high in the central Andes around Cuzco, in modern-day Peru, had similarly humble origins to the Aztecs, but their rise to imperial status was, if anything, even more meteoric. They began as a small, somewhat disregarded tribe and developed their own strategies to coopt neighboring groups into a successful empire.

The Incas' origin myth told of their emergence from a cave in the high mountains, from where their first leader—Manco Capac—led his people to Cuzco. It is generally believed that the Incas arrived in the region around 1200, and for two centuries

they remained a relatively insignificant farming group, with their society divided up into clans (*ayllus*) of roughly equal status.

Inca expansion

The Incas began to make their mark as a major power around 1438, when the neighboring Chanka people attempted to push the Incas out of the Cuzco valley. By this time, the Incas had a supreme leader (the Sapa Inca), and although the incumbent Viracocha was unequal to the task, his son Pachacuti defeated the invaders, and then led Inca armies to conquer the rest of the Cuzco valley and the southern highlands around Lake Titicaca. Under Pachacuti's son Topa Inca Yupanqui and grandson Huayna Capac, the Incas overcame Chimor (the largest coastal state) in about 1470. They then absorbed the rest of the northern highlands and extended to parts of modern-day Ecuador and Colombia and south to the deserts north of Chile.

Unlike the Aztecs, the Incas recruited troops from among the conquered peoples (placed under the command of Inca officers), thus providing them with the lure of plunder in return for their loyalty.

Inca communication

The empire of the Incas was highly centralized; censuses recorded the number of peasants, who all owed labor service (*mitad*) to the Sapa Inca. This level of organization enabled the construction of public works on a vast scale. Particularly vital was the extensive road network,

Tlacaclael

As the Aztec Empire expanded and conquered new territories, it became increasingly necessary to create a more complex system of administration. After Itzcoatl became ruler (*tlatoani*) in 1427, he introduced the new post of chief adviser (*chihuacoatl*). The office's first incumbent was Itzcoatl's nephew,

Tlacaclael (1397–1487), who held the office until his death. Tlacaclael served through several reigns and he provided invaluable continuity. In addition, he created impetus for his reforms (mostly benefiting the royal family and nobles) by ordering the destruction of earlier chronicles and the rewriting of Aztec history to establish the basis of Aztec imperial ideology.

He also presided over the formation of the Triple Alliance, solidifying the Aztec position and ensuring a steady stream of sacrificial victims. Given that Tlacaclael was never the Aztec's ruler, his immense influence in Tenochtitlan shows that the Aztec system of authority was not as monolithic as it might at first appear.